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California to Ban 5 Hazardous Food Additives for a Healthier Future

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California, the Golden State, is setting its sights on popular candies and snacks, striving to become the first state to ban the sale, manufacture, and distribution of foods containing five chemicals linked to cancer risk, reproductive harm, and behavioral issues in children. AB 418, co-sponsored by State Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, targets red dye No. 3, titanium dioxide, potassium bromate, bromated vegetable oil, and propylparaben, referred to as "the worst of the worst".

Europe has long since banned these additives, and potassium bromate, a suspected carcinogen, is also prohibited for human consumption in China and India. Interestingly, red dye No. 3 has been banned in cosmetics in the U.S. since the 1990s. Processed foods often contain thousands of chemicals to improve taste, freshness, and color, with potassium bromate being present in an estimated 100 products.

Gabriel's "ah-ha" moment came when he learned that 99 percent of these chemicals escape FDA review. Dana Hunnes, a senior clinical dietitian at UCLA, shares his concerns. She warns that the more we consume a particular product, the more likely we are to experience negative side effects.

However, the food industry isn't backing down. Business associations are contesting the proposed legislation, asserting that the U.S. federal government's comprehensive food safety process has deemed the five additives safe. The FDA maintains that all food additives require a pre-market evaluation and that their scientists continuously review new information to ensure ongoing safety.

For instance, the FDA claims that potassium bromate, when used correctly, converts into a harmless substance during food production. While not all of the compound may convert in a given recipe, control measures are in place to minimize its presence in final products. Despite these assurances, many consumers, like Ashley and Jermaine Rawlings, are cautious about what they feed their children and support the proposed legislation.

Most Americans are likely unaware of the dangers associated with these substances, which are considered hazardous in Europe. Erik Millstone, a food additives expert at the University of Sussex, believes that many people simply assume products available in stores are safe. Supporters of California's bill hope it will inspire change across the nation.

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